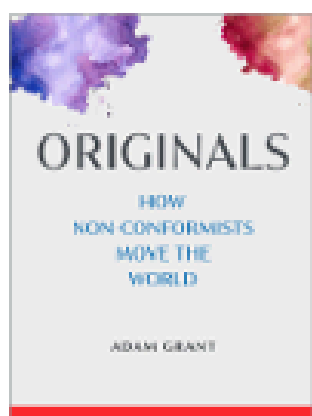




ORIGINALS

How Non-conformists Move The World

ADAM GRANT

The Big “So What”

Most major breakthroughs in our world are made by a handful of people who dare to think differently. Grant calls them the “Originals”. In this book, he shows that **creativity can be nurtured, and explains how each of us can think originally to make a greater impact.**

Introduction

Being original is simply about taking a less traveled path to pursue fresh ideas and improvements, even if they conflict with the prevailing norms. It involves having a novel concept and taking action to make it a reality.

It's a myth that Originals are revolutionaries with inborn talents, unusual passion and conviction, and a huge appetite for risk. The reverse is true—**Originals are ordinary people, and anyone can choose to think differently.**

 Most people conform to norms in hope of fitting in and avoiding failure. Originals also have their fears and self-doubt. In fact, many famous people didn't pursue/publish their ideas until they were “forced” to do so.

- Michelangelo refused to paint the Sistine Chapel ceiling because he saw himself as a sculptor rather than a painter. He only agreed to the project after 2 years at the Pope's insistence.
- Steve Wozniak started Apple with Steve Jobs in 1976 but refused to leave his full time job at Hewlett-Packard (HP). He only made the leap in 1977 when an angel investor agreed to fund Apple on the condition that Wozniak left HP.

KEY QUOTES

“This book proves that any one of us can champion ideas that improve the world around us.”

“The hallmark of originality is rejecting the default and exploring whether a better option exists.”

“In search of excellence and in fear of failure, most of us opt to fit in rather than stand out.”

“The people who move the world forward with original ideas are rarely paragons of conviction and commitment...they, too, grapple with fear, ambivalence, and self-doubt.”

- Martin Luther King, Jr. never wanted to lead the civil rights movement. His dream was to be a pastor and college president. Yet, he was swept up by a chain of events after he was nominated as the president of the Montgomery Improvement Association.

 New, untested ideas are naturally risky. Yet, Originals are not reckless risk-takers. Instead, they tend to take calculated risks and develop balanced risk portfolios. Similar to how successful investors build a balanced investment portfolio, successful people balance the risks in their lives—if they take an extreme risk in 1 area of their life (e.g. business), they'll balance it with extreme caution in other areas (e.g. family).

Using various real-life stories and examples of how Originals succeed and fail, **Grant presents useful insights and tips to improve our chances of successful innovation.** In this summary, we'll present the key ideas in 2 parts:

- Managing the Risks of Originality; and
- Unleashing Originality at Work and at Home

Managing the Risks of Originality

Often, the challenge with creativity is not the lack of fresh ideas, but selecting the right ideas and getting buy-in to make them a reality.

Generating and selecting ideas

 Being an Original starts with being curious. Don't simply accept the status quo—understand why it exists and challenge how it can be improved. Realize that all rules and systems are man-made and can be changed.

 A key to originality is to come up with more ideas, and use feedback to figure out which ones work.

- We are bad at predicting which creations will work. Creators typically go back-and-forth between fresh ideas and old

KEY QUOTES

"To become original...means accepting some measure of risk. But the most successful originals are not the daredevils who leap before they look."

"In reality, the biggest barrier to originality is not idea generation—it's idea selection."

"Rules and systems were created by people. And that awareness gives us the courage to contemplate how we can change them."

"Put a lot of ideas out there and see which ones are praised and adopted by your target audience."

ones that they'd previously rejected, until they hit on a winning idea.

- Our first ideas are usually the least creative. As we reject them, we gradually open ourselves up to newer and better options. Rather than try to perfect the few ideas you have, develop more options and test them.

 As you build the breadth and depth of your experience, it expands your frame of reference and improves your creativity.

- Learn a new craft. Entrepreneurs and creators who're involved in the arts (e.g. painting, music, literature) tend to be more creative, since they offer new ways to express ideas and feelings using images, sounds, and words.
- Acquire new skills and knowledge by requesting for a job rotation or volunteering for new projects.
- Widen your cultural exposure by working overseas for several years, ideally immersing yourself in culture(s) that are very different from your own.

 Procrastination may be bad for productivity, but can be good for creativity. The key is to procrastinate strategically.

- When a task is incomplete, it stays active on our mind. Take a break after working on an idea—let it incubate while you explore new options, so you avoid being prematurely fixated on an idea.
- In an experiment, students who procrastinated delivered proposals that were 28% more creative. King's famous "*I Have a Dream*" speech in 1963 was written only the night before the event, even though he started gathering material and advice months prior. In fact, the most memorable lines from the speech (including the dream angle) were improvised on the day itself. King was able to do so because he had a wealth of material without prematurely committing himself to 1 angle.

 Tapping late-mover advantages. It's a common misconception that to be original, you must be the first. Conventional business wisdom says that the first party to launch a new product/technology has an edge in terms of market share and learning.

KEY QUOTES

"Procrastination may be the enemy of productivity, but it can be a resource for creativity."

"Great originals... procrastinate strategically, making gradual progress by testing and refining different possibilities."

"The most successful originals don't always arrive on schedule. They are fashionably late to the party."

- However, the risks of being the first mover can greatly outweigh the benefits. Pioneers of a new product were found to fail 6x more than “settlers” who entered only after the market was developed. Pioneers who survived also had less than half of the settlers’ market share. This is because (a) pioneers are more likely to *overinvest* in something the market is not yet ready for, and (b) settlers can take the time to learn from pioneers’ mistakes, adapt to changes in the market/consumer tastes and *balance their risk portfolios* before entering the market.
- It’s not always bad to be the first to market. However, don’t rush in just to be the first; focus on learning, adapting and reducing your risks instead.



It’s a myth that older people can’t innovate. In fact, we can deliberately sustain our creativity by adapting our style of thinking.

- It’s true that most innovative breakthroughs come from younger people up to 30-35 years of age. They typically get a creative insight and focus on executing it—an approach called conceptual innovation. The process is much faster, but the creator may lack new inspiration after the initial creation.
- On the other hand, experimental innovation involves solving problems through trial and error, learning and evolving along the way. This approach takes years, but the accumulated data, knowledge and skills form the foundation for future discoveries.
- As you age, continuously experiment with different ideas and solutions; as you build your experience, you may uncover a big idea. Leonardo da Vinci started working on *The Last Supper and Mona Lisa* in his late 40s/early 50s; for both works, he only knew what he wanted to create *after* he started drawing.



Using intuition vs analysis. Our intuitions are only accurate in areas where we’ve accumulated lots of experience in a predictable environment. In such cases, our brains learn to recognize patterns that allow us to make quick but sound decisions. However, when we lack domain expertise and/or a

KEY QUOTES

“It’s true that the early bird gets the worm, but we can’t forget that the early worm gets caught.”

“Being original doesn’t require being first. It just means being different and better.”

“Good things come to those who wait, and for experimentalists, it’s never too late to become original.”

consistent environment, we should use proper analysis instead of relying on our intuition.



Evaluate ideas using peer feedback.

- We tend to be overly-positive about our own creations, while managers tend to be overly-negative about novel ideas that don't meet existing norms. People who take on the role of an evaluator (as members of a test audience or a focus group) also tend to unconsciously assess an idea based what they think should work. Ironically, the more expertise you have in an area, you more you're likely to reject ideas outside the current norms/rules.
- The best people to get feedback from are your peers or fellow creators, as they're more likely to have the domain knowledge to evaluate the idea without being colored by vested interests.



Let's look at how the insights above played out in a couple of real-life examples :

- Warby Parker. Back in 2008, Luxottica controlled >80% of the eyeglasses market and could charge 20x of the cost price, resulting in outrageously expensive eyeglasses. 4 frustrated students came together to explore ways to offer cheaper eyewear. The team had diversified background in bioengineering, healthcare, consulting, and banking, and 3 of them wore glasses. To manage their risks, they attended an entrepreneurship class, ran surveys and focus groups to identify what people felt about buying glasses online, and developed options to address customers' concerns before launching their free "home try-on program". With all the key ingredients in place, Warby Parker took off; in just 5 years, it grew to >\$100mil annual revenues with a valuation of >\$1bil.
- Segway (a self-balancing personal transporter) turned out to be a flop despite initial hype that it'd be a game-changer. Even big names like Apple's Steve Jobs, Amazon's Jeff Bezos and legendary investor John Doerr believed the technology would be a hit. However, the Segway eventually failed as the team fail to obtain enough critical feedback to refine the product. Even Steve Jobs failed to evaluate the technology correctly because his passion and confidence led him to

KEY QUOTES

"As we gain knowledge about a domain, we become prisoners of our prototypes."

"We often speak of the wisdom of crowds, but we need to be careful about which crowds we're considering."

skip a thorough analysis of this new technology even though he lacked domain experience in transport (being more familiar with computers and design).

Voicing and Championing Original Ideas



How you push for an unconventional idea can affect your career, relationships and determine whether the idea gets adopted.

❌ When you're pitching your idea, highlight the downsides, e.g. why someone should not invest in your project, or why they should not buy your business. This works because:

- People are naturally skeptical of new ideas. When you share your weaknesses, they move from defensive to problem solving mode.
- If the audience already recognizes the weaknesses, it makes you seem more trustworthy.
- People assume that those who're more critical have more expertise and are more discerning. Experiments show that reviewers of a book/artpiece are perceived to be smarter if they simply replace a few positive words with negative ones (e.g. "inspired" to "uninspired").
- It triggers a mental bias to bring a more positive evaluation. People who're asked to list 3 happy things feel better about their lives compared to those who're asked to list 12. That's because most people can list 3 happy things easily, but struggle to think of 12 things (which makes them feel their lives aren't so good). Highlight 3 key weaknesses and invite your audience to think of other issues—when they struggle to find other problems, they'd assess your proposal more favorably.



Make your idea familiar. Many creators make the mistake of *under-communicating* their idea—they've spent so much time on their idea that they forget others are not as exposed to it.

- The more familiar we are with something, the more we like it because it becomes less threatening and easier to process. To make people comfortable with a novel idea, repeat

KEY QUOTES

"Leading with weaknesses disarms the audience."

yourself at least 10-20x, using short messages mixed with other ideas. Space them apart by a few days to maintain curiosity and give time for the idea to sink in.

- Connect your concept to other ideas that are already understood by the audience. Disney's team struggled with the concept for the Lion King movie until they framed it as "Hamlet in a Savannah setting"—to convey the idea of family feud amongst lions.

 Moderate your approach. If you push a radical idea directly, people will resist; yet if you tone it down too much, it may lose its impact. To succeed, you must be willing to temper your idea and present it in a way that appeals to the mainstream audience.

- Reframe your idea in terms of values or beliefs that others already hold, or show how your idea supports their goals. When pushing for women's voting rights, Frances Willard didn't argue for societal reform or justice. Instead, she appealed to gender-role stereotypes by calling it a "home protection ballot" for conservative women to protect their homes from alcohol abuse.
- Focus on "how" instead of "why", to shift the attention from differences in convictions to gaps that can be filled. In 2011, Meredith Perry sought to create wireless power chargers by converting ultrasound vibration to power. All the experts insisted it was impossible. She stopped telling people what she wanted to create; instead, she got different experts to design different components (transmitter, receiver etc.) based on her specs, before putting them together. By 2014, she had completed her prototype and her company uBeam had secured 18 patents and \$10mil of venture funds.

 Seek out the right people. We tend to share our ideas with friendly people who'd agree with us. However, this means we may not get the critical feedback needed to hone our ideas. Seek the feedback and support of people who have a track record of challenging status quo, trying new ideas, and are willing to seek improvement over protection of status quo.

 Build power and status. Power involves authority over others, while status involves having others' respect. You need both to effectively champion an idea.

KEY QUOTES

"If we want people to accept our original ideas, we need to speak up about them, then rinse and repeat."

"To draw allies into joining the cause itself, what's needed is a moderately tempered message that is neither too hot nor too cold, but just right."

"Status cannot be claimed; it has to be earned or granted."

- The ideas above can improve your chances of pitching a radical idea without jeopardizing your career. However, if your voice constantly falls on deaf ears, it may better to exit the organization and pursue your options elsewhere.
- For years, CIA analyst Carmen Medina tried to push for a classified internet platform for intel agencies to share intelligence. Her idea was shot down by everyone and she eventually left her job. Less than 10 years later, she played a vital role in the birth of Intellipedia, a Wikipedia equivalent for intel agencies. This time round, her work itself involved the internet and she changed the way she presented her ideas. This allowed her to build credibility while pushing her agenda without seeming to fight the status quo. She was also backed by a tough boss who was ready to make changes to improve the CIA.

Managing Emotions



Change triggers feelings like fear, doubt and anger. **To see your ideas through, you need to manage your own emotions and overcome others' negative feelings toward change.**

♥ Both optimism and pessimism are useful coping strategies. Pessimism can lead to despair, but can also help to mitigate risks.

- If you're feeling unsure, use "strategic optimism" to stay calm, set high expectations and expect the best, until you've rebuilt your confidence and commitment.
- Once you've settled into a specific course of action, use "defensive pessimism" to avoid complacency. Imagine everything that can go wrong and prepare thoroughly to minimize your risk.

👤 When you're feeling anxious, you can manage your fears in 2 ways: by calming down, or by channeling the anxiety productively. Generally, it's easier to switch your emotional state from fear to excitement, than to try and calm yourself down. This is because:

KEY QUOTES

"In some circumstances, leaving a stifling organization can be a better path to originality."

"Rather than trying to suppress a strong emotion, it's easier to convert it into a different emotion—one that's equally intense, but propels us to step on the gas."

- When you're fearful, your body is pumped with adrenaline and in "go" mode. Thus, it's easier to tell yourself "I am excited" than "I am calm".
- Fear comes from uncertainty about the future. Since the future can also be positive, you have reason to be excited.



The best way to inspire people is to share a vision, then invite the customers or beneficiaries to share how this impacts them personally. This creates an emotional impact and makes the message seem more authentic. When University scholarship students called potential donors to describe how the donations could help them, they raised 3x the average amount of donations.



However, an inspiring vision alone is not enough. To motivate action, people must feel a sense of urgency to change now.

- The key is to leverage people's loss-aversion. Nobel Prize winner Daniel Kahneman found that people will prefer an option with a higher chance of a smaller gain, over an option with a lower chance of a bigger gain. When facing a potential loss, people will prefer to avoid the loss at all cost, even if it means risking an even bigger loss.
- Thus, if something seems risky, people will cling to status quo even if they see the potential benefits of change. You must show them what's wrong with the status quo and emphasize what they'll lose if they don't change. Make the gap between "what is" and "what it could be" as big as possible, and amplify their sense of frustration or anger.
- To renew commitment and confidence when people are wavering, focus on the investment and progress that's already been made and would be wasted if you give up. Once commitment is secured, look forward and focus on what needs to be done.
- On New Year's Eve of 2000, Serbian political activist Srdja Popovic and his friends organized a celebration in the Republic Square. Close to midnight, the square went dark and people began counting down. At midnight, instead of rock bands and performances, people were shocked to hear depressing music followed by an announcement that there

KEY QUOTES

"The leader's message provides an overarching vision to start the car, and the user's story offers an emotional appeal that step on the accelerator."

"The prospect of a certain loss brings the go system online."

was nothing to celebrate after a year of war and oppression. That night, Serbians went home with the message that 2000 was the year for change.

- To push for innovation, Merck CEO Kenneth Frazier asked leaders to generate ideas on what'd put Merck out of business. As the executives brainstormed challenges and defensive moves, they realized the risks and potential losses if they stuck to status quo; they were now ready to embrace innovation.



Channelling anger. Anger can drive us to take action, but such actions are unlikely to be effective.

- Studies in anger management found that venting your anger (e.g. by hitting a punching bag while thinking of the perpetrator) only feeds the anger and aggression. It's also stressful and exhausting to suppress your feelings.
- A better response is to focus on the victim. This makes you more empathetic and allows you to channel your anger constructively, to help the victims rather than seek revenge or retaliation against the perpetrator.
- To manage potential racial conflicts, King ran workshops for thousands of black Alabamans to simulate abuse by "white passengers", with the goal of training participants to manage their anger so they wouldn't resort to violence and worsen the situation. King also urged victims to focus on freeing their own children and preserving their dignity, not on defeating the white men.

Creating and Maintaining Coalitions



When seeking support, we tend to look for groups/people who share common goals/beliefs. However, it may be better to seek those who share common tactics.

- Common goals don't always work because radical groups tend to adopt an extreme "all or nothing" view which makes it hard for other moderate groups to relate to them.

KEY QUOTES

"In seeking alliances with groups that share our values, we overlook the importance of sharing our strategic tactics."

- Instead, those who share the same tactics as us will tend to feel a sense of affinity even without the same values/beliefs. For example, someone who participates in protest marches is likely to relate to another who's protesting for a different cause.



Work with your enemies, not frenemies. We tend to think most positively of our friends and most negatively of our enemies. We'd generally favor a frenemy (who swings between supporting and undermining us) over an enemy. However, when it comes to alliances, it may be better to cut off the frenemies and try to win over our enemies.

- Research found that predictably-negative relationships are less stressful than ambivalent ones that keep you second guessing.
- When you convert someone from negative to positive, they tend to be more motivated to maintain a positive relationship. They're also more effective in persuading others to join us, since they know others' concerns and appear more credible.



Unleashing Originality at Work and at Home

Nurturing Originality in Children



Research shows that “laterborns” have a higher tendency to take risks due to sibling rivalry and parenting style. **By adjusting how discipline is enforced, parents and teachers can influence how kids respond to rules and exercise originality.**



Focus on values over rules. Parents of highly creative children tend to impose fewer rules and explain decisions based on principles and values like morality, respect, or perseverance.

- When children understand the rationale behind the rules, they're more likely to follow and internalize them. They're also more likely to develop empathy and be aware of the consequences of their actions.

KEY QUOTES

- Be flexible if your children challenge inconsistencies in your rules and decisions; don't insist that they follow the rules blindly.



Role-modeling is a vital part of a child's development.

- Nurture creativity by exposing your children to various role models, such real-life stories of Originals, or even fictional characters who follow unconventional paths.
- Get your children to consider different perspectives by examining asking questions like, "what would this Original do in a situation like this?" or "how would things have turned out differently if he/she had grown up in a different culture?"



Reinforce good behaviors by associating them with good character. When children are praised for their character (e.g. being generous or kind), they are more likely to internalize it as part of their identity.

KEY QUOTES

"Reasoning does create a paradox: it leads both to more rule following and more rebelliousness."

"Role models have a foundational impact on how children grow up to express their originality."

"Character praise leaves a lasting imprint when identities are forming."

Cultivating Originality at the Workplace



One of the biggest enemies of originality is groupthink, i.e. the tendency to follow the majority instead of embracing diversity.



Build a culture that promotes diversity and creativity.

- Bridgewater—which handles some \$170bil of investments—has a strong culture built on the principle that people must think for themselves. The commitment to think differently has allowed the company to identify trends and opportunities that no one else in the market has considered, and to avoid following erroneous market sentiments. Employees are expected to share their concerns and critiques of one another (including the leaders), and may even be fired for not speaking up.
- When hiring new staff, consider their cultural contribution, i.e. whether the staff adds to the diversity in backgrounds, skill sets, and personality traits. Conduct entry interviews to get new hires' suggestions, rather than do exit interviews only when people are leaving. Find creative ways to widen

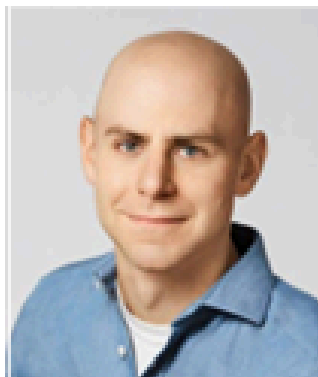
"If you're going to build a strong culture, it's paramount to make diversity one of your core values."

"The greatest shapers don't stop at introducing originality into the world. They create cultures that unleash originality in others."

parents and teachers. In this summary, we've outlined several key examples and distilled the main insights and actionable tips.

For more resources, details and a free assessment of your originality, please visit www.adamgrant.net

About the Author



Adam M. Grant (born 1981) is an American author and a professor at the Wharton School of the University of Pennsylvania. He received a B.A. from Harvard College, and M.S. and Ph.D. degrees from the University of Michigan in organizational psychology. At the age of 28, Grant became the youngest tenured professor in Wharton School's history.

In 2015, Grant was named a World Economic Forum Young Global Leader and a Thinkers50 Most Influential Global Management Thinker. He was also named to Fortune's 40 under 40 in 2016,

KEY QUOTES